The HR Integration Dilemma After V Company's Cross-border Acquisition

V 公司跨国收购后的人力资源整合困局

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0 Introduction

0 引言

In June 2017, in the Shanghai office of the Chinese branch of Group E, Chen De, the former HR manager of T Company, along with his colleagues, moved office supplies from the 9th floor to the 10th floor. This seemingly small step represented a significant shift: they went from being employees of a South Korean company to becoming employees of the Chinese private enterprise, V Company.

2017 年 6 月，在韩国 E 集团中国分部的上海办公室里，原 T 公司人力资源部经理陈德和他的同事们正将办公用品从 9 楼搬往 10 楼。这看似微小的一步代表了一个重大的转变：他们从一家韩国企业的员工，转变为中国民营企业 V 公司的雇员。

Months earlier, Chinese private apparel company V Company had executed an “A snake swallowing an elephant” acquisition, officially absorbing T Company, a fashion brand previously owned by South Korea's Group E. Although the view from the windows remained the same, the interior environment made Chen uncomfortable: T Company had been a vibrant space filled with blue tones, logos, and clothing samples, while V Company’s office had white walls, red Chinese knots, wooden floors, and neatly organized cubicles, creating a solemn and serious atmosphere. Chen knew that the real challenge had just begun—could the integration of these two vastly different companies succeed?

几个月前，中国民营服装企业 V 公司进行了一场“蛇吞象”式的收购，正式将原属于韩国 E 集团的时尚品牌 T 公司收入囊中。尽管窗外的景色依旧，但室内的环境让陈德深感不适：T 公司以往是一个充满蓝色调、随处可见标识和服装样品的活力空间，而 V 公司的办公室则是白墙、红中国结、原木地板和整齐的格子间，氛围严肃庄重。陈德知道，真正的挑战才刚刚开始——这两家差异巨大的企业，其人力资源整合能成功吗？

1.The "Elephant Swallowing a Snake" Acquisition

一场“蛇吞象”式的收购

1.1 The Crisis of the Long-standing Korean Enterprise

老牌韩企的危机

Group E, the largest fashion retail group in South Korea, had T Brand under its umbrella. T Brand, known for its youthful women’s fashion and iconic cartoon image, had about 4 million loyal customers and over 1,000 stores in China. However, around 2010, Group E's South Korean parent company faced a debt crisis due to failed investments, and T Company in China failed to adapt to the internet transformation, leading to a decline in performance. With both internal and external challenges, Group E decided to sell T Company in China.

韩国第一大时尚零售集团 E 集团旗下拥有 T 品牌。T 品牌以其青春女装定位和标志性的

卡通形象而闻名，在中国拥有约 400 万名忠实客户和超过 1000 家门店。然而，2010 年前后，E 集团韩国母公司因投资失败面临债务危机，而中国 T 公司未能适应互联网转型，导致业绩下滑。在内忧外患之下，E 集团决定出售中国 T 公司。

1.2 Private Enterprise Strategic Acquisition

民营企业的战略吞并

V Company, a Chinese private apparel enterprise, had far fewer assets and a smaller sales team compared to T Company. V Company's own brand focused on high-end women's fashion, and its founder, Mr. Weng, had strategic ambitions to build a multi-brand fashion group, similar to the French Kering Group, which owned brands such as Gucci and Puma. V Company saw T Brand's broad market influence and product lines as a foundation for its future brand pyramid. In January 2017, V Company acquired 100% of T Company for nearly 6 billion RMB, a move that put a significant financial strain on V Company.

V 公司是一家中国民营服装企业，其总资产和销售团队规模远小于 T 公司。V 公司的自有品牌定位高端女装，其创始人翁先生怀有构建多品牌时尚集团的战略野心，对标拥有古驰、彪马等品牌的法国开云集团。V 公司看中了 T 品牌的广泛市场影响力和产品线，意图将其打造成未来品牌“金字塔”的塔基。2017 年 1 月，V 公司以近 60 亿元人民币收购了 T 公司 100% 的股权，此举给 V 公司带来了巨大的财务压力。

1.3 New Operations Under the "Guarantee Agreement"

《保障合约》下的新运营

To ensure a smooth transition, V Company signed a “Guarantee Agreement” with T Company's employees, promising no layoffs during the transition period and no fundamental changes to the basic systems (such as compensation). After the acquisition, V Company quickly reorganized, merging the functional departments of both companies and implementing a brand-based business division system.

为确保平稳过渡，V 公司与 T 公司员工签订了《保障合约》，承诺在过渡期内不裁员，且基本制度（如薪酬）不发生根本性改变。收购后，V 公司迅速重组，合并了两家公司的职能部门，并实行了品牌事业部制。

2.Differences Are Everywhere

差异无处不在

2.1 Cultural Differences

文化差异

T Company had a mature and unique “campus culture” with a detailed manual. New employees were required to undergo 21 days of residential training. The company adhered to a strict schedule: collective reading and sharing at 7 AM, morning exercises and departmental slogans at 8 AM, office cleaning at 8:30 AM, and only then did the day's work begin. The culture had distinct Korean and Christian characteristics: strict hierarchy, clear distinctions between juniors and seniors, care for employees' families, encouragement for employees to leave work on time to spend time with their families, and a ban on smoking and drinking.

T 公司拥有成熟且独特的“校园文化”，并配有详细手册。新员工需接受 21 天的合宿培训。公司遵循严格的日程：早上 7 点集体阅读和分享，8 点早操和喊部门口号，8 点半打扫办公室，之后才开始一天的工作。其文化带有鲜明的韩国民族和基督教特征：等级森严、前后辈界限分明、关爱员工家庭、鼓励员工准时下班陪伴家人、禁烟禁酒。

In contrast, V Company promoted a “wolf culture,” emphasizing aggression and pragmatism. Its corporate culture was still evolving, with employees working more independently.

相比之下，V 公司推崇“狼性文化”，强调进攻性和务实。其企业文化尚在形成阶段，员工工作方式更为独立。

2.2 Embarrassing Workplace Interactions

尴尬的职场交往

Cultural differences quickly led to awkward situations. The next day, Chen De bowed respectfully in the hallway to his Korean superior, just as he had in the past at the Korean company, which surprised V Company employees.

文化差异很快导致了尴尬的局面。第二天，陈德在走廊里像在韩企时一样向他的韩籍上司恭敬鞠躬，这让 V 公司的员工感到惊讶。

At a banquet hosted by V Company’s president, Mr. Weng, to celebrate the move, the cultural conflict became public for the first time. During the meal, T Company’s Korean senior and middle management politely but firmly stated that, due to their Christian faith, they could not drink alcohol. Other Chinese employees from T Company, including Chen De, also silently refrained from drinking, as was customary to follow their superiors. Mr. Weng and V Company employees awkwardly kept their glasses raised in mid-air but ultimately withdrew. From then on, both sides tacitly stopped dining together at formal events.

在 V 公司总裁翁先生为庆祝搬迁举办的宴会上，文化冲突首次公开化。席间，T 公司的韩籍中高层管理人员礼貌而坚定地表示，由于基督教信仰，他们不能饮酒。T 公司的其他中国员工，包括陈德在内，也习惯性地跟随上司，沉默地没有举杯。翁先生和 V 公司员工尴尬地将举杯的手停在半空，最终只能收回。自此，双方默契地不再在正式场合共同用餐。

The year-end party further highlighted the differences. T Company employees all wore cultural T-shirts and performed a synchronized, positive energy dance, considering it an opportunity to showcase team cohesion. V Company employees, however, dressed in Halloween costumes and performed quirky skits and cross-dressing dances, viewing the event as an opportunity to relax and entertain. The style of the event was starkly divided.

年底年会进一步凸显了差异。T 公司员工统一穿着文化衫，表演整齐划一、充满正能量的团体舞，将其视为展示团队凝聚力的机会。而 V 公司员工则身着万圣节服装，表演搞怪小品和反串舞蹈，将活动视为放松娱乐的机会。整个活动的风格截然不同。

2.3 Conflicts in Work Collaboration

工作协作中的冲突

The ways of conducting meetings revealed fundamental conflicts in work philosophy. T Company’s meetings were well-prepared, focused on reports, with little input from subordinates; V Company’s meetings were open discussions, often accompanied by intense debates. When they attended meetings together, T Company employees remained silent while V Company employees waited for others to speak, and both groups felt that communication was impossible.

开会方式揭示了根本的工作理念冲突。T 公司的会议准备充分，以汇报为主，下属很少发表意见；V 公司的会议则是开放式讨论，常伴有激烈争论。当一起开会时，T 公司员工保持沉默，而 V 公司员工则等待对方发言，双方都觉得无法沟通。

In setting business goals, T Company was accustomed to setting targets that exceeded its actual

capabilities, to show ambition; V Company, on the other hand, pursued realistic goals, ensuring that targets were discussed, revised, and achievable. This left President Weng confused about whether T Company’s targets could be achieved.

在制定业务目标时，T 公司习惯于设定超出其实际能力的目标，以显示进取心；而 V 公司则追求务实的目标，确保目标经过讨论、修正并可实现。这让翁总裁对 T 公司的目标能否达成感到困惑。

After the acquisition, V Company unified the attendance system (9 AM to 6 PM), abruptly halting T Company’s long-standing morning rituals (reading, exercises, cleaning). Initially, employees were pleased, but after two months, many employees told Chen that they missed the ritualistic mornings and felt a lack of energy.

收购后，V 公司统一了考勤制度（早 9 晚 6），突然停止了 T 公司长期以来的晨间仪式（阅读、早操、打扫）。起初员工感到高兴，但两个月后，许多员工告诉陈德，他们怀念那些有仪式感的早晨，并感觉缺乏活力。

2.4 Confusion in Values

价值观的困惑

At the end of 2017, a survey conducted by Chen De on value alignment yielded shocking results. The mismatch between T Company employees' personal values, perceived organizational values, and expected organizational values was alarmingly low, reflecting employee confusion, suspicion, and dissonance with the new organization. There was significant variation in answers, suggesting that the new organization’s values had not yet resonated with the employees.

2017 年底，陈德进行的一项关于价值观匹配度的调查得出了令人震惊的结果。T 公司员工的个人价值观、感知到的组织价值观和期望的组织价值观之间的匹配度低得惊人，反映了员工对新组织的困惑、猜疑和不认同。答案差异很大，表明新组织的价值观尚未深入人心。

3. The Difficulty of HR Integration

人力资源整合之难

3.1 Conflicts Post-Restructuring

组织结构调整后的冲突

After the restructuring, conflicts within functional departments emerged due to differing business philosophies:

整合后，由于业务理念不同，职能部门内部出现了冲突：

-Finance Department: T Brand allocated large budgets for market research, which was rejected by V Company’s finance director.

-财务部：T 品牌为市场调查划拨了大量预算，但遭到 V 公司财务总监的否决。

-PMC Department: The inventory management methods differed significantly. T Brand had high inventory but a strict system, which V Company employees didn’t understand.

-PMC 部：库存管理方法差异显著。T 品牌库存高但有严格的体系，V 公司员工对此不理解。

-HR Department: V Company’s business division set different commission schemes for each store without prior evaluation, which T Company employees thought was uncontrollable; T Brand’s unified incentive system was criticized by V Company employees for not maximizing motivation.

-人力资源部：V 公司事业部为每家门店设定了不同的佣金方案且不做预先评估，T 公司员工认为这不可控；T 品牌的统一激励制度则被 V 公司员工批评为无法最大化激励。

The structural changes also caused management difficulties. For example, the regional manager in Shanghai used to manage 20 T brand stores (women’s, men’s, children’s apparel), but after the split by sub-brands, it now required three managers. This led to a reduction in the responsibilities of the former top-performing manager, and the talents were not being fully utilized, leading to a shortage of talent and rising labor costs.

组织结构变更也带来了管理难题。例如，上海的区域经理原本管理 20 家 T 品牌门店（女装、男装、童装），但按子品牌拆分后，现在需要三位经理。这导致原优秀经理的职责缩减，人才能力无法充分发挥，同时出现了人才短缺和人力成本上升。

3.2 Compensation System Reform: A Ripple Effect

薪酬体系改革：牵一发而动全身

The integration of compensation systems was one of the biggest challenges, as it was closely linked to assessments and promotions.

薪酬体系的整合是最大挑战之一，因为它与考核和晋升紧密相关。

-Bonus System: T Company’s bonus pool fluctuated significantly based on performance, and individual bonuses were determined by mandatory distribution, resulting in large fluctuations; V Company aggregated individual target bonuses from the bottom up, which were then adjusted based on KPIs, making the amount relatively stable.

-奖金制度：T 公司的奖金池随业绩大幅波动，个人奖金通过强制分布确定，波动大；V 公司自下而上汇总个人目标奖金，再根据 KPI 调整，金额相对固定。

-Promotion and Job Levels: T Company valued abilities and used a seniority-based promotion system, where promotions could come without changes in responsibilities but with salary increases; V Company’s promotions were based on job requirements, where job levels and real authority were fully matched. The actual meaning of the “manager” title and the treatment differed greatly.

-晋升与职级：T 公司重能力，采用年限晋升制，晋升可能伴随职责不变但薪酬上涨；V 公司的晋升基于岗位需求，职级与实际权力完全匹配。“经理”头衔的实际含义和礼遇差异很大。

-Fairness of Compensation: In T Company, Korean employees’ salaries and benefits (including high allowances) were much higher than their Chinese counterparts, which had been accepted because of the dispatch from the Korean headquarters. After the acquisition, however, this sparked a strong sense of unfairness.

-薪酬公平性：在 T 公司，韩籍员工的薪酬福利（含高额补贴）远高于同级中国员工，过去因由韩国总部派遣而被接受。但收购后，这引发了强烈的不公平感。

-Welfare System: T Company had generous benefits (such as Korean language courses, family medical check-ups, children’s scholarships), while V Company’s benefits were more basic. This led to a conflict during integration, as T Company feared reductions, while V Company envied the benefits.

-福利制度：T 公司福利优厚（如韩语学习、家庭体检、子女奖学金），而 V 公司福利较为单一。整合时面临 T 公司怕削减、V 公司羡慕的矛盾。

3.3 Recruitment System: Mature or Cumbersome?

招聘制度：成熟还是繁琐？

T Company had a strict and standardized campus recruitment process (online application templates, standard questions, personality tests, three rounds of interviews), which was the primary source of talent and created a unique "class" culture. V Company, however, allowed department heads or managers to make decisions directly, with a simple process and no standardized procedures.

T 公司拥有严格规范的校园招聘流程（网申模板、标准问题、性格测试、三轮面试），这是其主要人才来源，并形成了独特的"届别"文化。而 V 公司则由部门总监或经理直接决定，流程简单，缺乏标准程序。

This resulted in significant differences in the educational backgrounds of employees (over 90% of non-sales positions in T Company were university graduates, while V Company's rate was around 40%), and both sides felt that "they were not the same type of people." The integration of the recruitment system faced resistance from V Company, who saw T Company's process as cumbersome and inefficient.

这导致员工学历构成差异显著（T 公司非销售岗位本科率超 90%，V 公司约 40%），双方都感觉"不是一类人"。招聘制度的整合面临 V 公司的阻力，他们认为 T 公司的流程繁琐低效。

3.4 The Unstoppable Wave of Resignations
挡不住的离职潮

Despite the "Guarantee Agreement," a wave of resignations could not be stopped. First, mid-to-senior level T Company employees left due to ideological differences, followed by some Korean employees who left due to unmet salary expectations. V Company's former HR director, downgraded to a manager after the acquisition, left when he saw no promotion opportunities, taking his team with him. By early 2019, nearly 20% of the core employees from the original two companies had chosen to leave, and rumors spread inside the company, causing unease among the staff.

尽管有《保障合约》，离职潮仍无法阻挡。先是 T 公司的中高层因理念不合离职，随后部分韩籍员工因薪酬预期不符而离开。V 公司原人力资源总监在收购后被降级为经理，在看到晋升无望后离职，并带走了他的团队。到 2019 年初，原两家公司的核心员工有近 20%选择离开，公司内部流言四起，人心惶惶。

4. Epilogue
尾声

Despite facing industry downturns and the challenges of the internet, T Brand's performance began to improve from the third quarter of 2017. Chen De and his team were working hard to establish new systems: reshaping values, unifying job levels, achieving equal pay for equal work, and optimizing the sales incentive system. These systems were planned to be officially implemented at the beginning of 2020, after the expiration of the "Guarantee Agreement."

尽管面临行业低迷和互联网的挑战，T 品牌业绩从 2017 年第三季度开始回升。陈德和他的团队正努力建立新制度：重塑价值观、统一职级体系、实现同岗同酬、优化销售激励体系。这些制度计划在《保障合约》到期后的 2020 年初正式实施。

Chen De believes that the key to long-term HR strategy is to shift from "buying talent" to

“cultivating talent.” The acquisition is not about one company submitting to the other, but a long process of the two companies complementing each other and building a new system together. “Although the new system has not yet been implemented and needs to be continuously improved in practice,” said Chen, “we are confident about the future.”

陈德认为，长期人力资源战略的关键是从“购买人才”转向“培养人才”。收购并非一方屈从于另一方，而是两家公司取长补短、共同建立新体系的漫长过程。“虽然新制度尚未实施，需要在实践中不断完善，”陈德说，“但我们对未来充满信心。”